raise your game.

So, after being realistic and honest with yourself, how do you pick a college where you stand a good chance of getting admitted? First, pick a college in another city. Leave home, stay in a hostel. Along with the freedom that you will enjoy, you will learn responsibility. If your parents can't afford a hostel, take a part-time job. There are plenty in the services sector. It will give you immense pride to pay your own way; it will teach you the value of money and the life lessons will be solid gold.

Pick a college that is not an obvious money spinner for their owners. There are many tell-tale signs such as fancy buildings and exteriors and sub-par academic facilities. Beware of colleges with five-star amenities. You are looking for a centre of learning, not a restaurant or a spa.

Go visit the college. Even if they don't offer a tour, walk around. Take it in. Talk to the students. Find out everything that is posted online. What areas do they specialise in? The newly accredited deemed universities seem to offer a wider range of options. For the first year at least, you want to play with many courses, before you decide on your path and choose your majors. Check out what is being said in the online student forums...it's the real stuff.

Read the faculty bios. Where did they study? How long have they been at the institution? How many have PhDs? Have they published papers, or written books? These factors determine the quality of the teaching staff.

When you visit, remember to check out their facilities—science labs, language labs, the library, sports facilities and resource centres. What online data bases will you have free access to?

Make a checklist of things you want to know—arrangements, if any, for internships and campus placement opportunities, the kind of companies that have come to campus, the placement rate. If there is a career counselling office and campus placement office. A good university must have credible post-graduate programmes under different faculties.

All this is necessary and will lead you to a good choice of college. But the most important check is your Attitude Check or your own state of mind. You will get from a college exactly what you extract from the experience. Who do you want to be when you graduate four years from now? Have a clear mental picture of the grades you will have, the knowledge and skills you will have acquired, the personality, the balance of mind and body, the character qualities you will develop.

There will be a pool of colleges available for your grade level, so figure out which is the best fit. Don't choose one because it is next to your home or where three of your best friends are going.

You're off on a great adventure. Have fun, make it count and get ready for life. If you have a great college experience, congratulations, you did it. If you have a poor experience, sorry, you did it. Over to you. ■

The author is an adman, businessman and mentor



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